In his biography of Curzon, Sir Harold Nicolson, appears particularly sympathetic to the man, painting a portrait of something like a troubled genius who lacked ‘people skills’ – a man whose intellectual abilities were so above the average, that it was hard for him to relate to others not as gifted. Hence, Curzon is described as being: irritable, lonely, intelligent, competitive, humorous, genial, emotional, charming, childish, egotistic, and many other things beside. The Earl of Ronaldshay gave positively glowing praise to Curzon in his biography: ‘So much courage, so gallant a bearing in face of so great difficulties, such passionate devotion and such high ideals provide an example and an inspiration which will long survive him’.[86] Ultimately, it would seem that Curzon was one of life’s dividing figures, eliciting great affection and admiration from some, and extreme hostility and derision from others. His tendency to change personality according to different people and circumstance made it particularly hard for both contemporaries and historians to fully get the measure of the man.

One thing that is certainly agreed upon is that when it came to Asia and the Middle East, Curzon possessed a confidence that propelled him to centre stage of any debate. For the one thing that Curzon aspired to be from an early age was an expert on Asia, and he would devote most of his life to such a pursuit. Curzon’s ambition in this arena was sparked while listening to a lecture by the imperialist writer James Fitzjames Stephen at Eton in 1877: ‘Ever since that day the fascination and sacredness of India have grown upon me’, Curzon confessed.[87] Between 1882 and 1895, he would make six extensive journeys through Persia, Russian Central Asia, Afghanistan, India, China and Japan, experiences which would do ‘much to colour his thinking about Britain’s place in the world’.[88] Above all, Curzon would be a staunch believer in the civilising mission of the British Empire, and the sacred trust involved in ruling India.[89]

It was this obsession with India that led to Curzon’s life-long animosity towards Russia, and his genesis as a Russophobe.[90] Interestingly enough, such a description is one that Curzon would never have accorded himself, declaring that he did not ‘class myself either with the Russophiles or the Russophobes’.[91] Yet, in all respects of the word, Curzon personified